FROM TEDIUM TO TRADECRAFT: *Deploying AI to the Front Lines of HUMINT Operations*

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Abstract

The integration of Artificial Intelligence presents a transformative opportunity for military operations, yet its safe application within Human Intelligence (HUMINT) remains unmapped. Currently, HUMINT professionals operate under chronic cognitive overload, burdened by tedious administrative and analytical procedures that consume their finite working memory and detract from face-to-face tactical tradecraft. The purpose of this exploratory qualitative case study was to develop a logic model to evaluate the operational feasibility of integrating AI across the spectrum of US Army HUMINT tasks.

Grounded in Cognitive Load Theory, the research systematically decomposed 426 doctrinal HUMINT sub-steps into standardized Occupational Information Network (O*NET) Generalized Work Activities (GWAs). The methodology utilized a five-phase algorithm to evaluate biological friction against Miller's Limit (Baseline Cognitive Load, L), determine the empirical percentage of a task capable of automation (Extraneous Ratio, E), and penalize theoretical utility using a Data Fidelity (D) multiplier and a doctrinally-rooted Risk Index (RI). The final integration Feasibility (F) was calculated using a Pythagorean Expectation formula to weigh cognitive relief against operational risk.

The data revealed that the average HUMINT task load ($L = 14.8$) exceeds the human biological limit by more than double, mathematically confirming the necessity for cognitive offloading. Crucially, the theoretical capability ceiling for AI automation peaked at 36.3%, structurally disproving the myth of full automation and mandating a Human-in-the-Loop (HITL) augmentation architecture. The logic model categorized 67% of tasks—predominantly administrative—as highly feasible for AI integration. Conversely, tasks relying on subjective human evaluation suffered severe exponential decay, isolating the tactical core strictly within the human domain. Statistical variance testing further confirmed an "Echelon Divide" ($p < .001$), demonstrating that current algorithms are optimized as force multipliers for command-and-staff management rather than for junior enlisted tactical collection.

Ultimately, this research suggests that the Department of War should prioritize AI acquisition based on the highest Integration Value (IV) rather than raw computational capability. By offloading extraneous friction, this mathematically scalable roadmap allows the intelligence community to preserve the operator's working memory, safeguarding human cognition as a sacred resource for high-risk tactical operations.

Keywords: *HUMINT, Artificial Intelligence, Cognitive Load Theory, Working Memory, Defense Acquisition, MOS 35M, Extraneous Load, Pythagorean Expectation.*

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